the REPORTER

Vol 12, Iss 2, Mar-Apr, 2026: Our Redeemer LCMS — **Lent / Easter**

Editor's Entry

This edition offers readers many opportunities for self-examination as we traverse through the Lenten season. Pastor Saunders and Pastor Knox complement each other, pointing to the problem of sin and rejoicing in our being saved from it.

I simply do not have the space to highlight all of the other thought-provoking articles within these pages, but I encourage you to use them to read and reflect this Lententide, preparing for the Easter celebration to come. Speaking of the Easter celebration, do not miss the Easter breakfast invitation!

-Michelle Bolin

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PASTOR'S POST

written by
Pastor Matthew BAKER

Why Wait?
(Part 2)

In my last *RepORter* article, I briefly reviewed our synod's and congregation's practice of Closed Communion and the Biblical and historical basis for it. Given the importance of sharing a unified belief about the Sacrament, it should be evident why we reserve the Lord's Supper until after an individual has been thoroughly catechized in the Lutheran faith. As Pastor Knox so succinctly and aptly puts it, when a person who has not yet been brought into Confessional Lutheran fellowship desires to receive the Sacrament of the Altar, the answer is never just, "No," it's always, "Not yet." That's the case whether the individual is a first-time visitor, an unconfirmed member of our congregation, or an adult seeking membership in the LCMS.

As I also wrote in the preceding article, withholding the Lord's Supper for a time is admittedly an easier position to defend than doing the same with Baptism. We would never dare to rank the Sacraments or put them in competition with one another, but we also shouldn't make the mistake of thinking that they're identical in function and application. For instance, as previously mentioned, the Lord's Supper comes with an admonition to examine oneself prior to receiving it (1 Co 11:27–29). There's no such requirement for Baptism. Conversely, our Confessions teach that Baptism is "necessary and effectual to salvation" (Ap IX 51; see also AC IX; LC IV 6); a claim not made of the Sacrament of the Altar. That's because along with the forgiveness of sins—as in the Lord's Supper—Baptism also gives new life in Christ. Of course, such a strong stance on the part of Lutherans isn't taken without Scriptural warrant (Mk 16:16; Jn 3:5; Rm 6:3–4; Ti 3:4–8).

Whereas we don't commune with members of other denominations or permit them to commune with us (with limited exceptions), we readily acknowledge the validity of Baptisms conducted in many other church bodies. Furthermore, the New Testament, particularly the book of Acts, provides several accounts of people being baptized immediately after being brought to the Chrisitan faith. These are all reasonable arguments for *not* delaying Baptism, even the Baptism of an adult convert. There are arguments that have been posed to me and I've had to teach about, which I'll do here as well.

That we would ever postpone Baptism for someone desiring it seems outrageous considering that we strongly promote the

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the Baptism of infants who haven't expressed such a desire. But therein lies the key. Remember, what's the big deal about Baptism? It's the giving of the Holy Spirit and the working of faith so that one is saved (Jn 3:6; Ti 3:5–6; Ap IX 53; LC IV 49 –50). Although Lutherans typically think of Baptism as the inception of faith in a person's life, we mustn't forget that Scripture doesn't state that faith comes exclusively through Baptism. One thing is absolutely necessary for faith—the Word of God (Rm 10:17).

The reality is, for many people, faith *precedes* Baptism. When the multitudes heard Peter's sermon on the day of Pentecost and were "cut to the heart" (Ac 2:37), you better believe that was the Holy Spirit at work in them. And what does Peter tell them to do? "Repent and be baptized" (v. 38). What—or rather, *who*—do you suppose compelled the Ethiopian eunuch to travel all the way to Jerusalem for worship (Ac 8:27)? It's no surprise that, after hearing the Gospel of Jesus Christ, he, too, is baptized (vv. 35–38). And in Acts 10, Luke tells us explicitly that Peter urged a group of Gentiles to be baptized *after* the Holy Spirit was poured out upon them as they heard his preaching (vv. 44–48).

So then, when an individual comes to the church and asks to be baptized because he wants to be a Christian, we shouldn't be so presumptuous as to insist that he isn't *already* a Christian. What's more, when such a person begins attending worship services regularly and commits to formal instruction in the Scriptures, these are almost certainly fruits of faith (Mt 7:18; 12:33 [Lk 6:43]; Jn 15:2–8). That isn't to say we dismiss the necessity of Baptism. The nature of the Sacrament doesn't change for someone who's previously heard the Scriptures and believed the Gospel. Baptism doesn't become just an affirmation of one's new life formerly begun in Christ. In the water and Word of Baptism, the Lord still "works forgiveness of sins, rescues from death and the devil, and gives eternal salvation" (SC IV 3). Baptism still stands as God's covenant with His elect, clothing them with Christ's righteousness and granting them an inheritance with Him in heaven.

At this point, some of you are undoubtedly raising the objection, "Pastor, all the New Testament examples you provided—as well as others (Ac 9:17–18; 16:30–34; 19:1–6; possibly also 8:12; 16:14–15; 18:7–8)—depict people being baptized immediately after hearing the Gospel or very shortly thereafter. So why do you make adults wait until after a lengthy period of catechesis?" First of all, notice that our practice is fully in alignment with the Scriptural model: we baptize adults once they've professed their faith and we subsequently baptize the children of those Christians (see again Ac 16:15, 33). Second, it should be noted that, with the exception of the jailer in Philippi (Ac 16:25–34), we're confident that all those baptized in Acts had at least some instruction in the Scriptures prior to Baptism, whether they be former Jews or those who had heard the teaching of the apostles. It's not as if Christians were baptizing pagans the same day they heard about the Triune God for the first time.

Third, we also shouldn't overlook the fact that Christianity in the first several years after Jesus was more unified than it is today. To be sure, there were factions, even early on, but Christianity wasn't nearly as splintered as it is in our hyper-individualized and personalized society. That meant that catechesis which began with one teacher was more likely to be consistent with that of another. The truth is, the "standard of teaching" which St. Paul commends in Romans 6:17 just isn't the reality for us anymore. Therefore, it's prudent for a pastor to be more discerning in his catechesis of people coming from outside his church body. Please understand, I, as a pastor, wouldn't be troubled in conscience if I baptized an individual and he shortly thereafter abandoned Lutheranism (even if I might be troubled in mind about my instruction). Nor would we question the perpetual validity of said individual's Baptism even if he joined a church body that denies it. At the same time, neither am I troubled in conscience by being patient in my work with a newcomer before jumping straight to Baptism.

The Church's response to external influences is evident in the catechetical and sacramental documents of the early centuries. Some of our oldest extra-Biblical records of Christian practice, including the *Didache* and Justin Martyr's *First Apology* (both of which were likely written in the second century A.D.), indicate that catechumens were required to undergo a period of instruction, demonstration of Christian living, and examination before being baptized. With the legalization and subsequent flourishing of Christianity in 313 A.D., even more precautions had to be set in place. In many cases in the fourth century, catechesis was extended to between one and three years before an individual was admitted to the Sacraments and church membership. (I'll also highlight that there was an expectation that supervised catechesis would continue even after membership was granted.) Many of you know that Our Redeemer's tradition of incorporating the Rite of Confirmation and first communion into the Easter Vigil service isn't our own invention. The Easter Vigil has historically been *the* time in the Church year when catechumens made their confession of faith, were baptized, and officially received the rights and privileges of being Christians, even if that meant months of waiting.

All this is to say that it's completely consistent with our doctrine of Baptism, the Scriptures, and Church history to ask new Christians to be patient as they eagerly await their incorporation into the body of Christ through the Sacrament of Baptism. As with the Sacrament of the Altar, we aren't denying them forgiveness, calling into question their faith, or imperiling their salvation. Rather, we're being respectful of a person's unique circumstances while also honoring the Lord's precious blessings to us by guarding them against misuse.

I, for one, am grateful for the continued arrival at Our Redeemer of inquisitive individuals seeking the truth about God, His Word, His Church, and His Sacraments. I delight to see in them—as I see in our current members—the working of the Holy Spirit to instill faith and bring more people into the heavenly kingdom. And I rejoice every time a person is brought to the waters of Baptism—be he an infant, child, or adult. This is how the Lord's Church has operated since its establishment and will continue to work until the closing of the age. To God be the glory!

REVEREND'S REFLECTIONS

written by
Pastor Michael **Knox**

"Your bill has already been paid."

Not long ago, my family and I went out for lunch after church. That's what we do most Sundays. Each week we have a discussion about what kind of food everybody wants, and whether we have to go to grandpa's favorite restaurant. When it's someone's birthday that week, he or she gets to pick the restaurant.

This particular week, we went to one of our regular places and ordered our food. The food was served. We enjoyed our meal and the table conversation. The waitress came by as she saw us finishing our meal. I asked her for the "check." She quietly said to me and Tammy, "Your bill has already been paid." I responded, "How's that?" to which she answered, "An anonymous guest took care of it." "How about the tip?" I asked. "Yes, even the tip," she said with a smile.

Paid in full! Of course, Tammy and I were thankful and pleasantly surprised.

But what would you think if the waitress hadn't told us about the anonymous guest? What if she had just let us pay the bill and kept the other payment for herself? You know that wouldn't have been right. It would have been stealing from the anonymous guest and from us, too.

While Tammy and I were quite ready and able to pay our bill at the restaurant, the same cannot be said of our "bill" or "debt" with God. The Word of God makes it clear that our good works, our cries for mercy, our begging for time, our promises to do better, even our own physical death, won't set things right between us and God. In Titus chapter 3, the Apostle Paul makes it clear that this is done for us only by Christ. **"But when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life**" (Titus 3:4-7).

In the Epistle to the Colossians, Paul further reminds us that the bill is "paid in full." **"And you, who were dead in your trespasses and the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses, by canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross"** (Colossians 2:13-14).

In these clear words, the Apostle proclaims this great truth: the sin you have inherited from Adam (you know that from confirmation class as "original sin"), as well as the sins you have committed since (all of them), Jesus took this sin upon Himself and paid the bill in full.

That's why in the confession of sins we normally use at the beginning of the Divine Service includes this cry,

> Almighty God, our maker and redeemer, we poor sinners confess unto You that we are by nature sinful and unclean and that we have sinned against You by thought, word, and deed. Wherefore we flee for refuge to Your infinite mercy, seeking and imploring Your grace for the sake of our Lord Jesus Christ.

There are false teachers in the world.

- ✝ Some tell their hearers that Christ paid some of the debt, the rest is up to you.
- ✝ Some tell their hearers that Christ paid the bill for some people but not for others.
- ✝ Some tell their hearers that Christ died as an example of love and now only forgives you as you love others.

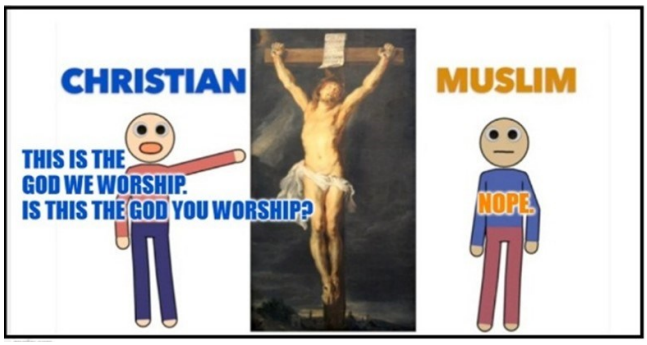
These false teachers, and others like them, steal from God and from those who listen to their lies. These false teachers rob their hearers of the true comfort and joy of knowing that, in Christ alone, their debt is paid and their sins are forgiven.

When my family went out to eat that Sunday afternoon, our meal was paid for by someone else. We didn't ask for it, we didn't seek it, we didn't earn it. A generous individual just paid for it in full. For that we are thankful. As we in the Church move through the Lenten season and anticipate the events of Holy Week, remembering the bloody passion of Christ our Lord, and His glorious resurrection and triumph over sin, death, and the grave, it is my privilege as your pastor to tell you again and again, your debt is paid, your sins forgiven. Together may we be thankful.

—Pastor Knox

QUICUMQUE VULT: IT'S TIME!

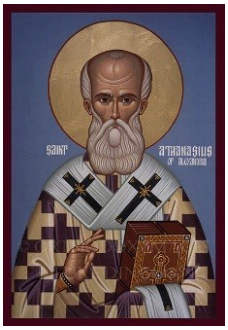
written by
Tom **WEMLINGER**



Most of us can remember exactly where we were when we first heard about the earth-shaking events that occurred during our lifetimes, e.g. the assassination of President Kennedy (I was in my junior high school cafeteria) or Elvis's passing (I was at Radio Shack, listening to the news on forty or fifty radios simultaneously). On September 11, 2001, I was in my office at Zion Lutheran Church, Marengo, IL, where I was serving my DCO internship. The secretary summoned me to the church office, where I watched in horror as the events at the World Trade Center unfolded. This was without a doubt a defining moment of our time. Things would never be the same after 9/11.

Unbeknownst to many, however, another monumental tragedy occurred less than two weeks after the attack on the Twin Towers: "A Prayer for America," an interfaith prayer service at Yankee Stadium that featured Muslims, Sikhs, Jews, Hindus, Catholics, and sundry mainline Protestants, all offering prayers to their various gods. Among this motley group of clerics and celebrities was the President of the LCMS Atlantic District, who had been given permission to participate by the Synodical President. As you can imagine, this set off a firestorm within the Synod. Since taking part in a syncretic event is in clear violation of Article VI of the LCMS Constitution, the participant was suspended by LCMS 2nd VP Dr. Wallace Schulz pending dispute resolution. At the conclusion of the resolution process, the suspension was overturned – and Dr. Schulz, for his trouble, was relieved of his duties as Lutheran Hour speaker a short time later. In response to a layman who had questioned his participation, the Atlantic DP offered the following justification via email: *"The Muslim God is also the true God (there IS only ONE TRUE GOD, right?) but worshipping [worshipped] in an inadequate way."*

Could this mess have been avoided? Perhaps. A proper understanding of the nature of God may have shed some light on why we don't join in prayers with pagans. More to the point, is the Muslim god the true God? Rev. Hans Fiene, on his Lutheran Satire YouTube channel, offers a concise and insightful – we mathematicians would call it "elegant" – proof to the contrary. (The cartoon is a screenshot from the video, which is well worth googling. And sharing.) Is there a handy guideline we can use in defending the faith? I present to you the *Quicumque Vult*, better known as the Athanasian Creed.



Quicumque Vult is Latin for "Whoever wishes," the opening words of the Creed ("Whoever wishes to be saved must, above all, hold to the catholic faith.") The creed is named for St. Athanasius (c. 296-373 A.D.), Bishop of Alexandria, who contended against the teachings of Arius at the First Council of Nicea in 325 A.D. The Arians, if you'll recall, taught that Jesus was a created being: "There was a time when He was not." The church roundly condemned this teaching as heresy and formulated the Nicene Creed, which incorporated the confession that Jesus Christ was "…of one substance (*homoousion*) with the Father." Although the Athanasian Creed did not come about until much later, it bears its name as a tribute to the staunch Trinitarian confession of St. Athanasius. This is one of the three Ecumenical Creeds (along with the Apostles' and Nicene Creeds) that are included in our Lutheran Confessions, to which we hold because (*quia*) they are in agreement with Scripture.

The Athanasian Creed beautifully sets forth our Trinitarian and Christological confessions, addressing errors and heresies that have plagued the church from the beginning. God has revealed Himself in three distinct persons but of one substance: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, co-equal and co-eternal. God is infinite, uncreated, and almighty, attributes shared by each of the persons of the Godhead. Each is God, yet there are not three Gods but one God. Against the Arians (e.g. Jehovah's Witnesses) we confess that Jesus "is God, begotten from the substance of the Father before all ages." Against the Modalists (e.g. Oneness Pentecostals) we confess that "we worship one God in Trinity and Trinity in Unity, neither confusing the persons nor dividing the substance." Against the Adoptionists (e.g. some Unitarian Universalists) we confess that the Son is "uncreated" and "eternal." Against the Docetists (e.g. practitioners of New Age spirituality) we confess that Jesus is "perfect God and perfect man, composed of a rational soul and human flesh." This, the creed itself reminds us, is the catholic faith, without which we cannot be saved.

Now, I'm not proposing an every-Sunday Athanasian Creed or anything outrageous like that (although I wouldn't dismiss it out of hand). I have heard of congregations that confess it once a month, or on every 5th Sunday of the month. I have been blessed to be able to confess it at least twice a year, once on Trinity Sunday and once on the Saturday before Trinity Sunday at Peace in Shell Rock. I do find it edifying, and I always seem to notice something new. And for those who are concerned about adding to the length of the service, I did the math for you: by word count, the Athanasian Creed is slightly less than three times as long as the Nicene Creed (1,305 vs 447). At the very least, you owe it to yourself to review it once in a while. Armed with the truths of the *Quicumque Vult*, you will certainly be better equipped for the battle against error in the church.

MEET OUR NEW MEMBERS!

written by
Sara LAIR

Let's meet the Gerdmans, a very busy family!

Doug and Erin, along with their children, Ben, Lauren and Megan, moved to Cedar Falls two and a half years ago from Osage, Iowa. Erin grew up in Osage; Doug grew up in West Allis, Wisconsin, a suburb of Milwaukee; thus, the family is diehard Milwaukee Brewers and Green Bay Packers fans. The Gerdmans were members at Trinity Lutheran Church in Osage and wanted to find a Missouri Synod church close to their home in Cedar Falls – Our Redeemer is a perfect fit.

Erin works from home as a project manager for NISC (a billing software company). Doug is a journeyman electrician and is working for Black Hawk Electric out of Waterloo and currently is working on the new high school project in Waterloo. Both Doug and Erin enjoy golf and watching their children play sports. Erin also enjoys walking the family dog.

Ben is a freshman at Peet Junior High and involved with football and baseball. He enjoys golf in the summer. He attends a weekly Bible study group with his friends. Ben hopes to play baseball in college and become a dentist.

Lauren in a 7th grader at Peet Junior High and is involved in volleyball, sand volleyball, softball, basketball and track. This summer she was selected to play in a sand volleyball tournament at Virginia Beach. Lauren is involved in the CAPs program this year and worked with the Waterloo Volunteer Center for her special project.

Megan, a 6th grader at Southdale Elementary, is involved in volleyball, softball, basketball, and track club. Her favorite subjects in school are math and physical education. She enjoys playing with the family mini goldendoodle, Archie.

Please welcome the Gerdmans to Our Redeemer!

Our Redeemer is pleased to welcome two new members: Ethan and Izie Newbrough.

Although not having grown up in Cedar Falls, both Ethan and Izie have ties to the Cedar Valley. Izie grew up in Texas, about an hour and a half from Dallas-Ft. Worth; Ethan is from Sioux City. However, they both have relatives in the area.

In searching for a church home, Ethan stated that, as he was reading the Gospels, he felt a need to find a conservative, Bible-based church. Despite growing up in a Lutheran congregation, Ethan had no knowledge of the Lutheran Church-Missouri Synod. After reading Our Redeemer's website, he decided to visit on a Sunday morning – and found exactly what he was looking for. Both Izie and Ethan took catechesis with Pastor Baker – Izie was baptized and both became members on February 1.

Ethan attended UNI and especially loved his time with the UNI Marching Band – playing percussion. A highlight of his band experience at UNI was going to Dublin, Ireland, with the band in 2019 – a wonderful experience!

Ethan works at Happy's Wine & Spirits in Cedar Falls. Izie is employed at CVS in Waterloo. In their spare time, the Newbroughs love playing with their dog, Mae. They enjoy camping and are planning a summer trip to the Grand Tetons and Yellowstone. Izie enjoys reading, ceramics, and art (entering and winning art competitions in Texas). Ethan enjoys cooking (especially grilling and smoking meats), watching movies, and working on cars.

Introduce yourself and get to know the Newbroughs!

ON REPENTANCE

written by
Christopher SELL

What is a Christian? Is it someone who goes to church? Is it someone who sings the loudest in service? Is it someone who gives away lots of money to the poor?

Christians are sinners, just like unbelievers are sinners. However, there is one thing that distinguishes Christians from everyone else: Christians repent. Christians have not refused to hear God's Word. As a result, they have been brought to the faith by the Holy Spirit in Holy Baptism.

Although repentance is the natural act of Christians as they live out their faith throughout the year, it is especially the topic of concern for the season of Lent. Lent is the season of repentance. As we prepare for the feast of Easter, we fast and deny ourselves, following our Lord Jesus as He, without complaint, is led to His innocent slaughter on the cross.

Repentance is comprised of two parts: contrition and faith. Philip Melanchthon writes the following about repentance in the Augsburg Confession: "Now, repentance consists properly of these two parts: One is contrition, that is, terrors smiting the conscience through the knowledge of sin; the other is faith, which is born of the Gospel, or of absolution, and believes that for Christ's sake, sins are forgiven, comforts the conscience, and delivers it from terrors" (AC XII).

This leads me to the main question I'd like you to think about: how do I know when I'm repenting? Is there a "right way" to repent? What if I repent incorrectly?

Let us break this down piece by piece. Repentance first starts with contrition. As Melanchthon writes, contrition is "terror smiting the conscience through the knowledge of sin." How do we receive this knowledge of sin? St. Paul gives us the answer in Romans 7:7: "if it had not been for the law, I would not have known sin. For I would not have known what it is to covet if the law had not said, 'You shall not covet.'"

We learn how sinful we are through God's Law or the Ten Commandments. By simply reading the first section of our Small Catechism and taking a look at the way we live, we easily receive this knowledge of sin.

It should scare us that we are sinners. Sinners deserve punishment. If being tormented in your body and soul in Hell forever in anguish does not scare you, nothing will. Even the rich man regrets his choice to refuse the Word of God: "I beg you, father, to send him to my father's house—for I have five brothers—so that he may warn them, lest they also come into this place of torment" (Luke 16:27-28).

Moreover, God promises to destroy all evil: "What do you plot against the Lord? He will make a complete end; trouble will not rise up a second time" (Nahum 1:9). It is God's promise that sin will not rise up a second time, meaning that, on Judgment Day, the very idea of evil will be completely and utterly destroyed forever. This includes all who practice evil, that is, the devil, his angels, and unrighteous, sinful people.

This is where most people stop. All people know that stealing is wrong. All people know that swearing is impolite. But if God is love, how can He punish like this? The expectations are too high; how can we make God happy? How can we be made right with God?

These people are missing the second part of repentance: faith. For Christians, the promise of the destruction of evil is actually a comfort. When Christ came down from heaven and became a man, He brought with Him good news. We find this good news, or Gospel, in the person and work of Jesus Christ. On our behalf, He lived a life without a single sin. On our behalf, He was "stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed" (Isaiah 53:4-5).

Repentance is completed when, in faith, sinners return to Christ on the cross and trust that His sacrifice was *for them*. They are absolved, without blame, without guilt, all because that blame and guilt was put on Christ.

So, during this season of Lent, let us repent. Let us remember our sins, feel sorrow and regret for our endless failures, and truly dread the torment of eternal Hell. But let us also remember who we are. As baptized children of God, Christ has remained faithful to us. He knows all our sins and failures, and yet being responsible for none of them, He still chose to bear the Father's torment of Hell on the cross. "All this he does out of his pure, fatherly and divine goodness and mercy, without any merit or worthiness on my part. For all of this I am bound to thank, praise, serve and obey him. This is most certainly true" (SC, Apostles' Creed I).

Prayer: Gracious Father, we thank you for the gift of your Word. By the hearing and preaching of this Word, we have learned that "our transgressions are multiplied before you, and our sins testify against us; for our transgressions are with us, and we know our iniquities" (Isaiah 59:12). However, having heard this message of fear, you have also shown us a

great light: your only Son, Jesus Christ, our Lord, the very Word incarnate, who willingly endured the agony and shame of the cross for our redemption. Grant us repentance during this penitential Lententide. May we join with the prophet Joel and sing, "return to the Lord your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love" (Joel 2:13). Grant us courage to take up our cross daily and follow Him wherever He leads, for we, your sheep, know your voice, and we follow you, and you only.

Let us suffer here with Jesus
And with patience bear our cross.
Joy will follow all our sadness;
Where He is, there is no loss.
Though today we sow no laughter,
We shall reap celestial joy;
All discomforts that annoy
Shall give way to mirth hereafter.
Jesus, here I share Your woe;
Help me there Your joy to know.

Let us gladly die with Jesus.
Since by death He conquered death,
He will free us from destruction,
Give to us immortal breath.
Let us mortify all passion
That would lead us into sin;
And the grave that shuts us in
Shall but prove the gate to heaven.
Jesus, here with You I die,
There to live with You on high.

(LSB 685:3-4)

Through Jesus Christ, your Son, our Lord, who lives and reigns with you and the Holy Spirit, one God, now and forever. Amen.

ANNOUNCING 2026 CAPITAL CAMPAIGN

written by
Greg GERJERTS

Goal: To Retire LCEF Loan Debt

Timeline:

- **Dec 2025**: ORLC Council secured a $110,000 loan from Lutheran Church Extension Fund to pay for: a) kitchen repairs from water damage; b) parsonage deck replacement; and c) a facility engineering study (FEC).
- **14 Feb 2026**: Capital Planning Committee formulated plans for: a) LCEF loan repayment (goal: by Nov 2026 voters assembly); and b) meeting 5-year recommendations in FEC (to be presented to the congregation after 16 Mar 2026 Council meeting).
- **16 Mar 2026**: Will request approval from Church Council to: a) seed capital campaign with $40,000 from unobligated funds residing in church share draft account; and b) authorize 2026 capital campaign to raise $70,000 through communicated appeals to the congregation.

Please watch for communicated information regarding the capital campaign and progress in loan repayment via *The RepORter*, Sunday bulletins, direct mail, and announcements following Divine Service and April voters assembly. The Capital Campaign Committee thanks you!

-Pastor Matthew Baker, Pastor Michael Knox, Tom Strub, Jonah Bolin, Eber White, Dave Kmoch, and Greg Gerjerts

DESCRIPTIVE VERSUS PRESCRIPTIVE PAULINE TEXTS

Hermeneutics & Parénesis & Kerygma, oh my!

Written by
Greg GERJERTS

Spurred by a thought I had during a Wednesday Bible Study, I decided to research the topic of interpreting biblical texts in terms of their being **"descriptive"** or **"prescriptive"** (see their relationship to "Imperative" and "Indicative" definitions, lower right). My research eventually led me to *A Project in Biblical Hermeneutics*, a monograph edited by Richard Jungkuntz and published in 1969 by The Commission on Theology and Church Relations (CTCR) of the LCMS. Currently housed in the Library at Concordia Theological Seminary, Ft. Wayne (CTSFW), it is a remarkable "old school" document featuring four primary authors, one of whom is **Dr. James W. Bartling** (pictured), who contributed Chapter IV, "Hermeneutics and Pauline Parénesis" (pp 57-83). I found myself engrossed in that single chapter for more hours than I care to admit—it is, as they say, "out of my league"—but found that it is not, through due diligence, inaccessible even to a novice. It is the foundation of this article (the walls and roof, one could also say).

Dr. Bartling (1924-2007) was born in Fergus Falls, Minnesota, son of the Rev. Victor A. Bartling (1896-1978), who was a longtime professor at Concordia Seminary, St. Louis (CSL). Dr. Bartling had a distinguished career as a Lutheran pastor, teacher and pastoral counselor, and he produced much scholarly work on behalf of both seminaries. His latter years were spent in the Decatur, Georgia, area, where, according to a brief obituary, he eventually succumbed to Parkinson's Disease.

Bartling's comprehensive study explores the hermeneutical challenges involved in interpreting New Testament ***parénesis*** in Paul's letters, and in "transferring" their meaning from a first-century context to contemporary application. As he writes: "We are not primarily concerned with preacher's fodder: 'true application,' 'legitimate application,' 'whatever practical application.' We are rather concerned with meaning, with primary meaning. What, in terms understandable in our day and our culture, did the apostle actually say when he spoke in terms understood in another day and a different culture? Only thus can one in any meaningful way claim to comprehend 'that which is written.'"

Before reaching his conclusions, Bartling amasses 18 challenging pages of text—challenging because of the subject matter's complexity, to be sure, but also in the sheer difficulty of "getting somewhere" with his pedagogy: "That the solution of the problem [i.e., translation and application] is quite beyond my grasp I am beginning to realize with stunning clarity," he admits. "But perhaps this is what some of us in the church need to learn. There are some questions that need very much to be asked but do not need to be answered—not finally, not completely, not once and for all. The answers come piecemeal in an occasional surmise—and quite by surprise. The anxiety that would force an answer stifles the surmise and blinds the spirit to surprise."

But, get somewhere he does, as evidenced by his concluding pages, which are presented herein largely intact.

This *repORter* article attempts to capture the essence of Dr. Bartling's erudition. That said, his original work, in its entirety, is the reader's best source for exploration and contemplation (citation is at end of article). As did I, you may find it challenging—but then we have all learned that most worthwhile endeavors are.

Useful Definitions:

- **Hermeneutics:** The branch of knowledge concerned with interpretation, especially of the Bible (or literary texts, generally).
- **Parénesis:** Theological term for moral exhortation, advice, and ethical instruction in New Testament writings.
- **Paraklesis:** A form of exhortation or encouragement often used synonymously with parénesis but with nuances of comfort and admonition.
- **Imperatives:** Commands or exhortations calling for ethical or moral action.
- **Indicatives:** Statements describing what has happened (theological truths, declarations).
- **Kerygma:** The first and essential proclamation of the Gospel. (The Gospel is the norm—perhaps better, the "root" or "ground"—and controlling principle for interpretation and application of parénesis.)

The Descriptive Versus the Prescriptive in the Study and Application of New Testament Parénetic Materials

A. Presuppositions arising out of the nature of the New Testament kerygma

1. The New Testament [NT, from here forward] kerygma is radically historical, centering in **the Christ event** (see 2.a).

2. All N. T. statements, inasmuch as they are kerygmatic witnesses, are radically historical, and that in four senses:

a. They are related to *what has happened in time* ("the Christ event").

b. They were originally addressed to people in historically contingent situations.

c. They are written by men whose witness is conditioned, both in the apprehension of that event and in its interpretation, by the historical particularity of their own situation in time and place.

d. They are addressed in the ongoing witness of the church's proclamation to men whose apprehension and interpretation of that witness is similarly conditioned.

3. All NT statements, inasmuch as they are kerygmatic witnesses, are addressed ***from*** faith ***to*** faith *(Vorverstandnis).*

B. Presuppositions arising out of the nature of the interpretative task

1. The primal obligation of interpretation is to promote understanding of the original witness by laying it bare in all its particularity of form and expression.

2. The goal of interpretation in the fellowship of the church is to "translate" the intention of the original witness into forms of expression which are valid and comprehensible in the particularity of new historical situations.

3. In achieving this goal, interpretation—to be true to its *Vorverstandnis* [literally, preconception or presupposition]—will be guided and controlled by a conscious and determined orientation towards the central Christ event.

***C.* Presuppositions arising out of the nature of New Testament parénesis**

1. NT parénesis is rooted in the kerygmatic witness to the Christ event and has as its goal that function of Christian witness which is life.

2. NT parénesis is the *usus practicus evangelii* [practical use of the gospel] and is not based in nor should it lead to casuistic legalism [i.e., resolving moral or ethical dilemmas by applying general principles to specific, complex cases].

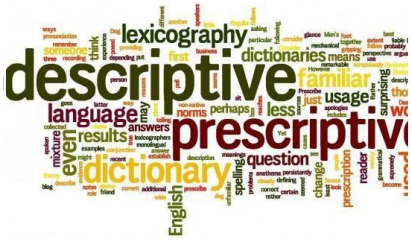
3. NT parénesis does not reflect the absolutes, the universals, or the ideals of a closed ethical system, but is illustrative for the creative novelty of the Spirit's power in that form of obedience which is faith and that expression of faith which is love.

4. NT parénesis differs, therefore, both in motive and in goal, from the Law *(nomos).*

Note: Parénesis is here understood in a broad sense to include all imperatival aspects of the kerygmatic witness: ethical injunctions, social directives, advice regarding conventional behavior, institutional and ecclesiastical guidelines, etc.

II. General principles suggested by the presuppositions

A. Principles suggested by the nature of the kerygmatic witness and of the interpretative task



1. The validity of every **descriptive** and **prescriptive** interpretation must be challenged by its coherence with the central Christ event.

2. Every churchly interpretation must deal with the total historical context from which and to which it was originally addressed and the total historical context in and for which it is being undertaken.

3. Every interpretation of a parénetic passage, especially at the **prescriptive** level, must confront the possibility—approaching almost to a certainty—that there can be no easy transfer from the "then" to the "now."

4. Thus, interpretation here lives in uneasy but necessary tension between the twin demands of faithfulness to the "then" and freedom in the "now."

B. Principles suggested by the nature of New Testament parénesis

1. The particular is not to be generalized.

2. The individual is not to be universalized.

3. The immediate is not to be institutionalized.

4. The illustrative is not to be systematized.

5. The parénetic is not to be legalized.

III. Guidelines for the specific instance—in the form of questions to be posed by the interpreter

A. Primary questions

1. How and how closely is the given parénetic statement related to the kerygmatic core of the NT revelation?

2. *Are there contemporary circumstances which evidently condition the form, or even occasion the substance, of the statement?*

B. Secondary questions

[Note that in each of 1-6 below, there is a certain presumptive force favoring a high degree of universality for the former alternative.]

1. Is the statement related to the common stock of primitive parénetic materials, **or** is it isolated and relatively unique?

2. Is the given injunction manifestly ethical, **or** does it partake more of the nature of convention and custom?

3. Is the statement in the form of a premise **or** of a deduction?

4. Is the statement in absolute **or** in hypothetical form?

5. Is the statement positive **or** negative in form?

6. Is the sanction inherent, **or** is the statement associated with appeals to authority?

C. Tertiary questions

1. Is there a consistent churchly tradition in the application of the statement?

2. Is there a self-evident rationality in a given interpretation and application?

3. Is there an obvious existential "contemporaneity"?

An interesting peripheral:

In our churches Mass is celebrated every Sunday. . . . We keep traditional liturgical forms, such as the order of the lessons, prayers, vestments, etc. (Ap 24:1) Some make the argument that this is merely **descriptive** rather than **prescriptive**—therefore it is purely optional. Some would even say this used to be descriptive and is actually expired or not true any more. And yet in spite of this, Lutheran pastors still take unqualified vows that this Book of Concord norms their ministry in the Church. The reality is this: the entire **Book of Concord** is descriptive—it describes the doctrine and practice of our churches. We do not obey the Book of Concord, rather we confess it. It describes our faith and explicates how we (Lutherans, that is) interpret the Scriptures.

Larry Beane, *Gottesdienst*, May 2013

I hope you found Bartling's (in his words) "first attempt to state hermeneutical guidelines" thought provoking, and that your various reactions to it were more inclined toward "Profound!" than "Nonsense!" If you do access the document online, don't skip the responses written by the review panel (pp 79-83). It was their job to find flaws—and they did that. I'm not sure who was the more erudite, Bartling or the panel!

See:

https://ctsfw.net/media/pdfs/JungkuntzAProjectinBiblicalhermeneutics.pdf

A Project in Biblical Hermeneutics

1969, Edited by Richard Jungkuntz

Chapter IV, "Hermeneutics and Pauline Parénesis"

Written by Walter J. Bartling

A VICAR'S APPRECIATION

written by
Dave **KMOCH**

If you've ever wondered how much our previous vicars value their ORLC vicarage experience, consider the recent feedback from one of our early vicars, David Zimmer (2002-2003). In a letter to the congregation, Pastor Zimmer noted:

> "More than two decades later, I can say without hesitation that my vicarage at Our Redeemer was not simply a requirement to be completed, but a formative gift—one that shaped my ministry, strengthened my faith, and deeply impacted my family."

Pastor Zimmer appreciated the preaching guidance provided by the vicarage program:

> "One of the greatest blessings of my vicarage was learning to preach under the guidance of a supervising pastor who brought years of experience, patience, and wisdom. That pastoral mentoring continues to echo in my preaching to this day."

He also noted the impact on developing his teaching skill:

> "Teaching was another vital part of the year. Whether leading adult Bible studies or instructing youth in confirmation class, the vicarage helped me develop a teaching style that was clear, faithful, and accessible—rooted in Scripture and the Catechism, yet attentive to the questions and struggles of learners of all ages."

Pastor Zimmer summarized his appreciation for ORLC's vicarage program:

> "Our Redeemer's commitment to the vicarage program bore fruit—not only in my life and ministry, but in my family as well. I remain deeply grateful for a congregation that invested in forming a future pastor and welcomed an entire family with Christian love."

Pastor Zimmer's letter is posted on the bulletin board in the Parish Hall if you'd like to read the entire text. If you're interested in supporting the development of future pastors like David Zimmer, you are encouraged to consider including ORLC's Vicarage Fund in your estate planning or charitable giving. Contact any member of the Endowment Committee (Dave Jackson, Cathy Niebergall, and Andy Janik) for additional information.

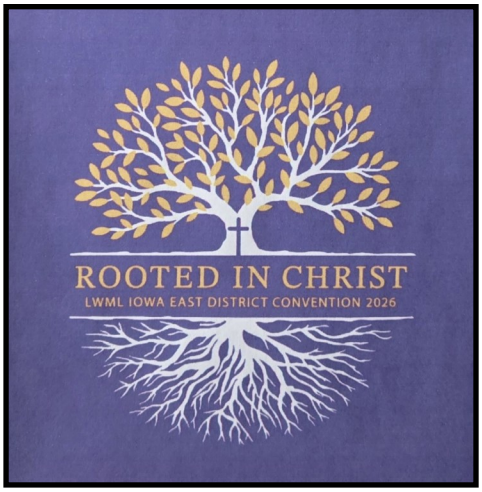
David Kmoch – ORLC Endowment Committee

IDE LWML DISTRICT CONVENTION

written by
Judy **FINK**

"Therefore, as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in him, rooted and built up in him and established in faith, just as you were taught, abounding in thanksgiving" (Colossians 2:6-7).

You are invited to attend the LWML Iowa District East Lutheran Women in Mission Convention, "Rooted in Christ," on June 12 and 13, 2026, at the Graduate by Hilton Iowa City (210 South Dubuque St., Iowa City, IA 52240).



The Keynote Speaker is the most Rev. Dien Ashley Taylor, Bishop and President of LCMS Atlantic District and Pastor at Redeemer Evangelical Lutheran Church in the Bronx, New York. There are opportunities to participate in Bible Studies, to hear from mission speakers, to be a part of the convention choir, to help with Servant Events by donating blood, to make greeting cards and assemble plastic mats for the homeless, and, of course, to enjoy the company of our sisters in Christ.

"Gifts from the Heart" will focus on children by collecting diapers and Christian books for babies and children as well as gift cards to buy books. These items will be distributed to shelters and women/family centers in Benton, Linn, and Johnson County. The hotel is located near the University, shops, museums, and restaurants.

Registration for the Convention opens on March 1, online only, at the LWML IED website. Individual Registration assistance is available, if needed. More information about the convention will be in the Parish Hall or you can contact Judy Fink with specific questions.

CARETAKERS

written by
Jonah **Bolin**

In Part 1, "In A Country Far, Far Away…," I first shared a brief overview of our hunting trip to South Africa, and how big-game hunting works there. Second, I shared how the conservation-minded hunter's outlook closely aligns with Christian stewardship towards nature, inspired primarily by Genesis 1 and 2.

As I mentioned, 59% of conservation funds come from hunting and fishing licenses, the rest of which comes from Pittman-Robertson Act funding, Dingell-Johnson funding, and other sources of state and federal funds[1]. While the other 41% of funding is pretty set, tied to percentages of state budgets or tax revenues, the funds and license numbers continue to decline.

Out of the 340 million Americans, only 14.4 million of them (less than 5%) are active hunters, which is less than half the percentage of what it was 50 years ago[2]. Compare that with the nearly 40 million anglers (one such aficionado preaches from Our Redeemer's pulpit), and you quickly notice that hunting is not as common as it once was. You might ask, "Hasn't the U.S. population grown enough in 50 years to account for that drop in percentage?" Not quite, and while costs have continually increased, licenses have not really caught up. Why is that? The short answer is public pressure and shift in culture.

Hunting in the United States has long caught the ire of environmental activists, animal rights groups, and even Christians who have tried to eliminate hunting altogether. They normally point to cases of poachers, hunting to extinction (think Western Black Rhinos or the American Bison in the late 1800s), mistakes (Cecil the Lion), reckless behavior, or accidents while hunting under the influence.

Let's give these critics their due and point out that God's creation is beautiful, awe-inspiring, and a testament to the One who created it. Psalm 104 describes in poetic detail individual aspects that draw so many to travel and see nature: the stars, deep oceans, mountains, canyons, wide valleys, and the creatures they are home to. Romans 1:20 describes God's transcendent qualities seeping through to sinful man's observation: "For His invisible attributes, namely, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made." These critics twist this appreciation, setting up humans as an insect-like disease that brings sin and violence to creation, pointing to Genesis 3, and claiming that, if we were to simply step back, we could "allow nature to heal." This is simply false, and Christians' failure to take up the caretaker responsibility has left a gap to be filled by an anti-humanist, pagan minority.

In the face of these critics, then, how is a Christian, specifically a Lutheran, supposed to handle this criticism if they enjoy hunting or would like to try it? Mostly ignore it and be thankful we live in a country where hunting is not reserved merely for the King and his nobles. Second, know your Bible verses that DO proclaim man's dominion over creation, following 1 Peter 3:15 and being prepared to give an answer.

Christ tells his disciples, "Therefore render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's" (Matt. 22:21). Aligned with the Fourth Commandment, we are called to obey and follow all laws when we engage in secular hobbies and activities, in this case, ensuring we have the proper animal tags and licenses if we are hunting in the United States or following the applicable visa and import/export requirements if hunting internationally. Next, be careful. Care for your fellow man and yourself by taking safety courses, shooting regularly to know your weapon, and taking clean kill-shots.

What is left then? Follow these no-brainers and you are now a caretaker-hunter-conversationist-outdoorsman. But when December rifle season comes, I pray your saintly behinds will be in the church pew on Sundays and not in a deer stand.

Sources:

[1]https://www.npr.org/2018/03/20/593001800/decline-in-hunters-threatens-how-u-s-pays-for-conservation
[2]https://www.fws.gov/story/2024-09/report-offers-snapshot-hunters-and-anglers-us

HELP US REACH OUT!

written by
Michelle **Bolin**

The Communications and Outreach Board meets bimonthly to plan for and execute various tasks related to communication within the congregation and outreach to our community. Examples of such tasks include the regular distribution of *The RepORter*, a recent letter sent to residents in the blocks surrounding the church, and last year's event where the decline in U.S. church attendance was discussed. While those examples do not encapsulate all that the Board entails, they do give a good picture of the goals of the Board: to streamline communication within our congregation and to reach out beyond the congregation, providing opportunities for fellowship.

With those goals in mind, the Board has discussed a few events and other ideas that would support those goals and is looking for individuals that would be interested in helping plan and/or execute the ideas, with the support of the Board. The ideas discussed are listed and described below.

- **Spring Cleanup**: A one-day spring event during which the congregation would volunteer to do some cleaning up in the surrounding area, helping dispose of old furniture, doing some spring yardwork, etc. The rental of a dumpster for community use has been discussed to support this event and as an extension of it.
- **Summer Block Party**: A summer event that might coincide with VBS (perhaps kicking it off or as an end-of-the-week celebration) where the community would be invited to OR to play yard games, enjoy typical summer foods, and get acquainted with the congregation.
- **OR Merchandise**: Having OR t-shirts, hats, and/or quarter zips would function both as advertisement when worn in the community and as a way to take pride in our congregation. While we have gotten shirts for VBS in previous years and have some old merchandise, a refresh of what we have and something more general, wearable by all members regardless of age, would be beneficial.

If you are at all interested in helping to plan for and execute any of these ideas, or if you have a related idea that you think would achieve the Board's goals, please reach out to any member of the C&O Board: Jim Niebergall, Sara Lair, Greg Gerjerts, and Michelle Bolin.

OUR REDEEMER EASTER BREAKFAST

written by
Judy **Fink**

Please join us for Our Redeemer's Easter Breakfast on Sunday, April 5, serving from 7:55 AM to 8:45 AM before the Easter Morning Divine Service. There will be a variety of goodies for everyone including egg casseroles, biscuits and gravy, muffins and coffee cakes, fruit, juice, and coffee. A free-will donation will be taken and all proceeds will be sent to the LCMS Disaster Response Fund to help victims whose lives have been disrupted by various disasters in our country.

Anyone wishing to help with preparations for the breakfast by furnishing muffins or coffee cakes, helping prepare on Saturday, or helping serve on Sunday, please contact Judy Fink. Please come and enjoy a great meal and conversation with Our Redeemer members before the Easter Service! This event is hosted by the Mary-Martha Guild.

HYMN CYCLE: Lent / Easter, Hymns To Peruse & Practice

March 1, 2026, Second Sunday in Lent
Readings: Gn 12:1–9; Rm 4:1–8, 13–17; Jn 3:1–17
Hymn of Invocation: We Sing the Praise of Him Who Died.....429
Hymn of the Day: God Loved the World So That He Gave 571
Distribution Hymn: Lord, Hear My Prayer.....*vocal ensemble*
Distribution Hymn: Water, Blood, and Spirit Crying 597
Distribution Hymn: Lord, Thee I Love with All My Heart 708
Distribution Hymn: O Love, How Deep 544

March 4, 2026, Lent 2 Midweek Vespers
Readings: 1 Co 15:1–11; Ti 2:11–14
Office Hymn: Jesus Christ, Our Blessed Savior ..... 627 (stz. 1, 3, 5, 9)
Closing Hymn: Cross of Jesus, Cross of Sorrow 428

March 8, 2026, Third Sunday in Lent
Readings: Ex 17:1–7; Rm 5:1–8; Jn 4:5–26
Hymn of Invocation: Glory Be to Jesus.....433
Hymn of the Day: Come to Calvary's Holy Mountain.....435
Distribution Hymn: Faithful Cross .....*choir*
Distribution Hymn: Alas! And Did My Savior Bleed 437
Distribution Hymn: O Holy Spirit, Grant Us Grace 693
Distribution Hymn: May God Bestow on Us His Grace 823

March 11, 2026, Lent 3 Midweek Vespers
Reading: 1 Co 11:23–26
Office Hymn: Jesus Christ, Our Blessed Savior .....627 (stz. 1–3, 8–9)
Closing Hymn: Not All the Blood of Beasts 431

March 15, 2026, Fourth Sunday in Lent
Readings: Is 42:14–21; Eph 5:8–14; Jn 9
Hymn of Invocation: Sing, My Tongue, the Glorious Battle 454
Hymn of the Day: Praise the One Who Breaks the Darkness.....849
Distribution Hymn: I Trust, O Christ, in You Alone.....972
Distribution Hymn: When to Our World the Savior Came.....551
Distribution Hymn: In the Cross of Christ I Glory 427
Distribution Hymn: Upon the Cross Extended 453

March 18, 2026, Lent 4 Midweek Vespers
Readings: 1 Jn 4:7–21; Jn 3:13–21
Office Hymn: Jesus Christ, Our Blessed Savior .....627 (stz. 1, 3, 9–10)
Closing Hymn: What Wondrous Love Is This.....543

March 22, 2026, Fifth Sunday in Lent
Readings: Ezk 37:1–14; Rm 8:1–11; Jn 11:1–45
Hymn of Invocation: The Royal Banners Forward Go 455
Hymn of the Day: O Christ, Who Shared Our Mortal Life 552
Distribution Hymn: In the Very Midst of Life.....755
Distribution Hymn: Go to Dark Gethsemane.....436
Distribution Hymn: Christ, the Life of All the Living 420
Distribution Hymn: Let Us Ever Walk with Jesus 685

March 25, 2026, Lent 5 Midweek Vespers
Readings: Rm 7:12–25; Jn 16:16–24
Office Hymn: Jesus Christ, Our Blessed Savior ..... 627 (stz. 1, 3, 7, 9)
Closing Hymn: Jesus, Refuge of the Weary 423

March 29, 2026, Sunday of the Passion
Readings: Jn 12:12–19; Is 50:4–9a; Php 2:5–11; Mt 26–27
Processional Hymn: All Glory, Laud, and Honor..... 442
Hymn of the Day: Ride On, Ride On in Majesty 441
Distribution Hymn: No Tramp of Soldier's Marching Feet 444
Distribution Hymn: A Lamb Goes Uncomplaining Forth..... 438
Distribution Hymn: My Song Is Love Unknown..... 430
Distribution Hymn: Hosanna, Loud Hosanna 443

March 30, 2026, Monday of Holy Week Midday Devotions
Readings: Is 50:5–10; Heb 9:11–15; Jn 12
Opening Hymn: Jesus, I Will Ponder Now.....440 (stz. 1, 4)
Closing Hymn: On My Heart Imprint Your Image..... 422

March 31, 2026, Tuesday of Holy Week Midday Devotions
Readings: Is 49:1–7; 1 Co 1:18–31; Jn 13–14
Opening Hymn: Jesus, I Will Ponder Now.....440 (stz. 1, 5)
Closing Hymn: On My Heart Imprint Your Image..... 422

April 1, 2026, Wednesday of Holy Week Midday Devotions
Readings: Is 62:11–63:7; Rm 5:6–11; Jn 15–16
Opening Hymn: Jesus, I Will Ponder Now.....440 (stz. 1, 2)
Closing Hymn: On My Heart Imprint Your Image..... 422

April 2, 2026, Thursday of Holy Week Midday Devotions
Readings: Ex 24:3–11; Heb 9:15–22; Jn 17
Opening Hymn: Jesus, I Will Ponder Now.....440 (stz. 1, 3)
Closing Hymn: On My Heart Imprint Your Image..... 422

April 2, 2026, Maundy Thursday
Readings: Ex 12:1–14; 1 Co 11:23–32; Jn 13:1–17, 31b–35
Hymn of the Day: Jesus, Grant That Balm and Healing 421
Distribution Hymn: Veni Sancte Spiritus .....*choir*
Distribution Hymn: The Death of Jesus Christ, Our Lord 634
Distribution Hymn: O Lord, We Praise Thee..... 617

April 3, 2026, Good Friday Midday Service of the Word
Readings: Mt 27:45–49; Lk 23:24–46; Jn 19:25b–30
Opening Hymn: Jesus, I Will Ponder Now.....440 (stz. 1, 6)
Responsory Hymn: Jesus, in Your Dying Woes..... 447
Closing Hymn: Stricken, Smitten, and Afflicted 451

April 3, 2026, Good Friday Divine Service
Readings: Is 52:13–53:12; Heb 4:14–16; 5:7–9; Jn 18–19
Passion Hymn: O Sacred Head, Now Wounded..... 450
Reproaches: Lamb of God, Pure and Holy 434
Distribution Hymn: O Dearest Jesus, What Law... 439
Distribution Hymn: O Perfect Life of Love..... 452

April 4, 2026, Great Vigil of Easter
Readings: TBA
Opening Hymn: All Creatures of Our God and King .....*printed*
Baptismal Hymn: All Who Believe and Are Baptized..... 601
Hymn of Praise: This Is the Feast 155
Distribution Hymn: The Strife Is O'er, the Battle Done 464

Continued on p. 14

Continued from p. 13

Distribution Hymn: Eat This Bread 638
Distribution Hymn: At the Lamb's High Feast We Sing..... 633
Distribution Hymn: Our Pascal Lamb, That Sets Us Free 473

April 5, 2026, The Resurrection of Our Lord

Readings: Ac 10:34–43; Col 3:1–4; Mt 28:1–10
Preparatory Hymn: Christians to the Pascal Victim.....*choir*
Processional Hymn: Jesus Christ Is Risen Today..... 457
Hymn of the Day: Christ the Lord Is Risen Today; Alleluia 463
Distribution Hymn: Awake, My Heart, with Gladness..... 467
Distribution Hymn: Christ Is Risen, Christ Is Risen! .....*choir*
Distribution Hymn: Christ Jesus Lay in Death's Strong Bands..... 458
Distribution Hymn: Christ the Lord Is Risen Today..... 469

April 12, 2026, Second Sunday of Easter

Readings: Ac 5:29–42; 1 Pt 1:3–9; Jn 20:19–31
Hymn of Invocation: He's Risen, He's Risen..... 480
Hymn of the Day: We Walk by Faith and Not by Sight..... 720
Distribution Hymn: These Things Did Thomas Count as Real 472
Distribution Hymn: Jesus Christ, My Sure Defense..... 741
Distribution Hymn: Hail, Thou Once Despised Jesus..... 531
Distribution Hymn: We Praise You and Acknowledge You 941

April 19, 2026, Third Sunday of Easter

Readings: Ac 2:14a, 36–41; 1 Pt 1:17–25; Lk 24:13–35
Hymn of Invocation: We Know That Christ Is Raised..... 603
Hymn of the Day: Who Are You Who Walks in Sorrow..... 476
Distribution Hymn: Lord Jesus Christ, with Us Abide..... 585
Distribution Hymn: With High Delight Let Us Unite 483
Distribution Hymn: Now All the Vault of Heaven Resounds..... 465

April 26, 2026, Fourth Sunday of Easter

Readings: Ac 2:42–47; 1 Pt 2:19–25; Jn 10:1–10
Hymn of Invocation: The Day of Resurrection..... 478
Hymn of the Day: In Adam We Have All Been One 569
Distribution Hymn: Today Your Mercy Calls Us..... 915
Distribution Hymn: Jesus Lives! The Victory's Won..... 490
Distribution Hymn: Good Christian Friends, Rejoice and Sing 475

Member Updates

Baptism

Izabelle Renee Newbrough, February 1, 2026

New Members

Ethan and Izabelle "Izie" Newbrough
603 ½ Iowa Street
Cedar Falls, IA 50613
Ethan: (712) 251-6576, ethann12345@gmail.com
Izie: (641) 481-5391, iziemoores98@gmail.com

Begging Your Attendance *(All locations @ ORLC unless otherwise noted.)*

March

2 Board of Elders, 6:30 p.m.
3 Brunch Bunch, 9:00 a.m.
4 Lenten Services, noon and 6:30 p.m.
9 Confession/Absolution, 6:30 p.m.
9 Special Council Meeting, 7:00 p.m.
11 Lenten Services, noon and 6:30 p.m.
16 Church Council, 6:30 p.m.
18 Lenten Services, noon and 6:30 p.m.
21 OR Women in Fellowship, 9:30 a.m.
23 Capital Campaign Meeting, 6:00 p.m.
23 Long-Range Planning Meeting, 7:00 p.m.
25 Lenten Services, noon and 6:30 p.m.
29 Palm Sunday Divine Services, 9:00 a.m.
30 Holy Week Midweek Readings, noon
31 Holy Week Midweek Readings, noon

April

1 Holy Week Midweek Readings, noon
2 Holy Week Midweek Readings, noon
2 Maundy Thursday Divine Service, 6:30 p.m.
3 Good Friday Readings, noon
3 Good Friday Divine Service, 6:30 p.m.
4 Easter Vigil (with confirmation), 6:30 p.m.
5 Easter Breakfast, 7:55 a.m.-8:45 a.m.
5 Festival of Easter, Divine Service, 9:00 a.m.
6 Board of Elders, 6:30 p.m.
7 Brunch Bunch, 9:00 a.m.
13 Confession/Absolution, 6:30 p.m.
18 Women in Fellowship, 9:30 a.m. (Cottonwood Canyon)
19 Voters Meeting, 1:30 p.m.
20 Endowment Meeting, 4:30 p.m.
26 Youth Disc Golf, 2:00 p.m.

May

4 Board of Elders, 6:30 p.m.
4-5 IDE Spring Pastors Conference
5 Brunch Bunch, 9:00 a.m.
11 Confession/Absolution, 6:30 p.m.
14 Ascension Day Divine Service, 6:30 p.m.
16 Women in Fellowship, 9:30 a.m. (Parish Hall)
18 Church Council, 6:30 p.m.

June

12-13 IDE LWML Convention, Iowa City
22-26 Vacation Bible School

Member Anniversaries, Mar-Apr

March

1 Laura & Josh Zummak
26 Jeff & Bee Sell

April

5 Doug & Erin Gerdman
9 Jeff & Nancy Bowker
15 Kristin & Ben Mather
28 Doug & Dottie Nefzger

Member Birthdays, Mar-Apr

March

1 Gerald Peterson
1 Jeff Bowker
1 Amber Stohr
5 Elwin Heth
8 Charlotte Strub
9 Molly Niebergall
12 Eber White
15 Zander Horner
18 Skyler Troge
26 Teddy Janik
29 Julie Faulker

April

1 Blake Wayson
2 Brighton Baker
3 Jim Niebergall
5 David Kmoch
5 Jake Jackson
9 Kayla Irwin
10 Martha Garms
11 Katy Troge
13 Charlie Janik
16 Elias Knox
22 Robert Blain
23 Maggie Janik
24 Joshua Swales
24 Janice Heth
26 Savannah Troge
27 Matthew Hundley
29 Christopher Fink

Duty Roster, Mar-Apr

- **Sunday, March 1**
  - Elder: Jonah Bolin
  - Ushers: Brad & Kaiser Bovy
- **Wednesday, March 4**
  - Elder: Jonah Bolin
- **Sunday, March 8**
  - Elder: Alan Czarnetzki
  - Ushers: Chris Fink & Dan List
- **Wednesday, March 11**
  - Elder: Alan Czarnetzki
- **Sunday, March 15**
  - Elder: Tim Koch
  - Ushers: Jim Niebergall & Gary Vander Werf
- **Wednesday, March 18**
  - Elder: Tim Koch
- **Sunday, March 22**
  - Elder: Jonah Bolin
  - Ushers: Roger & James Mishler
- **Wednesday, March 25**
  - Elder: Jonah Bolin
- **Sunday, March 29**
  - Elder: Rod Lair
  - Ushers: Scott & Brody Irwin
- **Thursday, April 2**
  - Elder: Alan Czarnetzki
  - Ushers: Stephen Hoffman & Kyle Winter
- **Friday, April 3**
  - Elder: Ryan Thornton
  - Ushers: Dusty & Casey Greiman
- **Saturday, April 4**
  - Elder: Tim Koch
  - Ushers: Al Nissen & Dean Garms
- **Sunday, April 5**
  - Elder: Stephen Hoffman
  - Ushers: Jason Knox & Steven Dekutoski
- **Sunday, April 12**
  - Elder: Jonah Bolin
  - Ushers: Greg Gerjerts & Dave Kmoch
- **Sunday, April 19**
  - Elder: Rod Lair
  - Ushers: Blake & Brody Wayson
- **Sunday, April 26**
  - Elder: Alan Czarnetzki
  - Ushers: Glen Staudinger, Eber White

SHEPHERD'S SPEAK

written by
Pastor Brian SAUNDERS

The Problem of Sin

The title of my article is supposed to invoke head scratching. As a whole, all of us agree that sin is a problem. But what I want to write about in this article is that there is a problem with the problem of sin.

We are now in the penitential season of Lent. The color purple for the paraments as well as the Scripture readings and hymns all reflect the fact we are in the midst of a season of examination for repentance. But here is the problem with sin: it is tempting to think of repentance as being sorry for a specific act, thought, or word. Recalling the sin to mind, our broken heart is contrite, and we confess it before our Lord who knows all things. Our confession opens our ears that we may hear how God has addressed our problem of sin by escorting His Son to the Cross of redemption.

Repentance is that, and more. Repentance is not only over the things we can recall that have violated the Law of God. It is also a confession of who and what we are. Individual sins are only a manifestation of a larger problem. The problem is the nature of our Old Adam. We are by nature, because of original sin, sinners who exemplify that nature in our deeds or lack thereof.

Let me use an illustration that might explain my point. In upper northwest Iowa, the soil is rich with nutrients and produces marvelous harvests. Yet, before the seed can be planted, the soil must be tilled for stones. There are actually farm implements designed to pick up the stones (most are quite large and would damage a disk or plow blade) before anything else is done. Now, one might think that picking them up should take care of the problem and one would not have to worry about it again. However, those stones were at one time part of a massive bedrock many feet below the soil. Each year, with freeze and thaw, portions of that bedrock break off and work their way to the surface. Thus, the need to comb the fields every year. The bedrock is so deep and vast that there will never be an exhaustion of stones breaking off and creating the necessity to gather them before any planting can be done.

The bedrock in the analogy is our Original Sin. Each and every day, Original Sin is manifested in one way or another by specific words, actions, thoughts, and misdeeds that violate God's Holy Law. During Lent, we are drawn to this fact and acknowledge that is the state of being handed to us from our Original Parents, Adam and Eve. We cannot escape it. We also cannot escape the fact that Original Sin raises its ugly head to the surface through visible and invisible sins throughout our lives.

I don't mean this to be a downer article. I write this for the benefit of the purpose of Lent. For 40 days we are reminded of the absolute necessity of "He who knew no sin, became sin for us, so that we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21). Lent drives us to Good Friday and parks its hope in the empty tomb. Because of Jesus' life, death, and resurrection, our indebtedness to God is as empty as the tomb that could not hold He who is the Lord of Life and forgiveness.

So next time you see a stone, remember that it came from a bedrock beneath the surface. So also, it should remind you that our actual sins are because of our original sin. Then remember that Christ Jesus came from above all surfaces to join Himself to us that He may deliver us from the headstone that will cover us. Because one day that stone will give way to the Resurrection of Eternal Life.

Blessed stoney Lententide.

—Pastor Saunders

Our Redeemer

904 Bluff Street
Cedar Falls, IA 50613

To: